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SEVEN MORE
STATIONS WILL
BE ADDED AFTER
ABU DHABI,
DUBAI, SHARJAH
AND FUJAIRAH

ABU DHABI
BY ALI AL HAMMADI
Reporter

Etihad Rail has announced the full details of the UAE's national passenger rail network, marking a major milestone in the country's transport and infrastructure development. The company said the network will connect 11 cities and regions across the UAE through strategically located stations, forming the nation's first fully integrated passenger rail system.

The project aims to enhance connectivity between the emirates while offering safe, reliable and efficient mobility for citizens, residents and tourists.

In early 2025, Etihad Rail announced the first four main stations in Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah and Fujairah. Yesterday, the company unveiled the remaining stations in Al Sila, Al Dhannah, Al Mirfa, Madinat Zayed, Mezairaa, Al Faya and Al Dhaid. These stations will be commissioned in phases.

Strategic shift

Commenting on the announcement, Eng. Ezzah Al Suwaidi, Executive Vice-President – Passenger Services at Etihad Rail, said the project reflects a strategic shift in the UAE's transport landscape.

"Our preparations to launch passenger rail services in 2026 reflect the vision of our leadership to build an integrated transport system that supports the country's economic and social growth," she said.

She added that the passenger network is a key pillar of the national transport ecosys-

11 CITIES, REGIONS TO BE LINKED BY ETIHAD RAIL THIS YEAR REVEALED



400

passengers can be carried by each train

57

minutes travel time from Abu Dhabi to Dubai on regular train

10m

passengers will be served annually by the network

10 of 13

trains have already arrived in UAE and completed testing

30

minutes will be travel time from Abu Dhabi to Dubai on high-speed rail

350 kmph

Maximum speed of the high-speed rail

TRAIN STOPS AT...

Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah
Fujairah, Al Sila, Al Dhannah,
Al Mirfa, Madinat Zayed,
Mezairaa, Al Faya and Al
Dhaid

teriors, onboard Wi-Fi and power outlets at every seat. Services will run on fixed schedules, offering a fast and reliable alternative to road travel.

Eng. Mohammed Al Shehhi,

Chief Projects Officer at Etihad Rail, said station locations were selected in coordination with local authorities to ensure easy access from residential and economic hubs.

Each train can carry up to 400 passengers, allowing the network to serve around 10 million passengers annually. Ten of the 13 trains have already arrived in the UAE and completed safety testing.

Travel times will include 57 minutes from Abu Dhabi to Dubai, 105 minutes to Fujairah

and 70 minutes to Al Ruwais. Passenger services will link destinations from Al Sila in the west to Fujairah in the east.

Etihad Rail reaffirmed that passenger operations will begin in 2026, with safety and service quality as top priorities.

The company also confirmed progress on its high-speed rail project, which will cut travel time between Abu Dhabi and Dubai to 30 minutes at speeds of up to 350kmph and is expected to add Dh145 billion to the UAE's GDP over 50 years.

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Dubai takes a major step towards driverless mobility

Emirate opens first driverless taxi control centre; first permit issued

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

Driverless-mobility in Dubai got a major boost yesterday with the launch of Baidu Apollo Go's Autonomous Vehicles Operations and Control Centre.

It is the first such facility for the Chinese tech giant outside China, reinforcing the emirate's ambition to lead globally in smart transport and artificial intelligence-driven mobility.

The centre serves as a comprehensive hub for managing autonomous vehicle operations, integrating a command-and-control centre, simulation and training rooms, and an operations and maintenance facility. It is designed to support safety testing, software updates, charging and maintenance, and rapid response to operational commands.

Mattar Al Tayer, Director General and Chairman of the Board of Executive Directors of



Dubai's Roads and Transport Authority (RTA), along with Yunpeng Wang, Corporate Vice-President of Baidu and President of Baidu's Intelligent Driving Group, inaugurated the 2,000-square-metre centre at Dubai Science Park yesterday. Commercial autonomous ride-hailing operations are scheduled to begin in the first quarter of 2026, with the fleet set to scale progressively to 1,000 vehicles.

RTA has also granted Baidu Apollo Go Dubai's first permit of its kind, authorising trials of fully autonomous vehicles on designated public roads without a safety driver behind the wheel. Apollo Go's expansion in the UAE is backed by its extensive global operational experience. The platform has logged more than 240 million kilometres in autonomous driving, including over 140 million kilometres in fully driverless mode without a human driver.

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